

• **Aide-mémoire** Plants have the power to evoke pleasant memories, either by sight or fragrance. They can change our mood in an instant, turning away sadness and replacing it with happy thoughts. Seeing a potted kalanchoe that your grandmother used to have may spark a treasured childhood memory; the scent of jasmine might be a reminder of your wedding day; a poinsettia suggests Christmas for many; while the scent of gardenia transports us to summer vacation. Many such plants hold positive associations that have the power to make us smile.

Nurturing

Tending plants in your home or office will help you reconnect with nature.

• **The feel-good factor** Losing yourself in the care of plants frees your mind from any immediate stresses. This reduces levels

“The appreciation of nature runs deep in our evolutionary makeup.”

of the stress hormone cortisol in your brain, resulting in calmer moods. Your mind is then focused on caring, which in turn releases dopamine, the hormone that makes you feel more positive and motivated.

• **Break the cycle** Caring for plants is absorbing and can soon become a regular hobby. This can help break the cycle of low moods and depression, as forming positive new habits is a recognized element in cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT).

The spider plant sprouts plantlets that can be cut off

Allow the baby plants to root in jars of water

Once rooted, the baby plants can be repotted

Planting pride
Propagating and nurturing your own plants can bring an uplifting sense of achievement. The spider plant (see pp.56–57) is a good choice to start with.

